

Mingyi Li

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Shenzhen, China

Research Interests

Applied Microeconomics; Environmental Economics; Urban Economics

Education

Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen

Ph.D. in Economics

2024 –

Shenzhen, Guangdong, China

– Advised by Wei Lin

Xiamen University

M.A. in Economics

2020 – 2023

Xiamen, Fujian, China

– Advised by Ying Chen

Southwestern University of Finance and Economics

B.A. in Finance

2016 – 2020

Chengdu, Sichuan, China

Working Papers

“Consumption Stimulus with Digital Coupons” with Ying Chen, Jiaming Mao, and Jingyi Zhou. R&R, JPubE

Abstract: We study consumption stimulus using digital coupons, which provide time-limited subsidies contingent on minimum spending. Analyzing a large-scale program in China, we find that the program generates large and heterogeneous short-term effects. Consumption responses vary across both consumers and locations, reflecting both demand-side and supply-side factors. This heterogeneity shapes the incidence of the program: high-response consumers tend to patronize larger businesses, leading to a regressive allocation of stimulus benefits. Through counterfactual analysis, we show that targeting rules can reshape both the size and distribution of stimulus effects. Targeting the most responsive consumers can more than double the aggregate stimulus, while a hybrid design that combines targeted distribution with direct support to small businesses improves both efficiency and equity.

Work-in-Progress

“The Regulator’s Dilemma: Land Use Efficiency in the Renewable Energy Expansion”

Abstract: This paper evaluates the land-use efficiency of agrivoltaic systems in China, an industrial policy designed to reconcile renewable energy expansion with agricultural preservation. To rationalize the economic frictions inherent in dual-use mandates, I develop a search-theoretic model characterizing firm behavior under imperfect regulatory screening. To test the theoretical predictions, I construct a novel spatial dataset matching administrative records of utility-scale solar farms with precise satellite-derived boundaries, employing a heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences design against a rigorous counterfactual group of unbuilt projects. I document a stark structural decoupling effect: agrivoltaic system deployment significantly reduces active agricultural production by 7.3 percent relative to the baseline mean, accompanied by a 6 percentage point absolute reduction in physical cropland share. I empirically disentangle the underlying mechanisms, demonstrating that this land abandonment is driven by the super-additive interaction of exogenous spatial search frictions and regulatory arbitrage by private firms. Counterfactual simulations highlight the regulator’s dilemma, confronting policymakers with a binding trade-off: maintaining a lenient regulatory environment to accelerate renewable energy expansion inadvertently subsidizes up to ¥247 million annually in pure regulatory arbitrage rents, allowing up to ¥376 million in agricultural value to evaporate through strategic abandonment. Conversely, attempting to recover these losses via strict enforcement acts as a prohibitive tax on spatial search costs, threatening to price out remote developers and sacrifice vital renewable energy capacity.

“Balancing Growth and Sustainability: the Impact of Coal-Fired Power Plants on Local Labor Markets” with Ying Chen and Shihe Fu

Abstract: In emerging markets, power shortages are a major obstacle to economic progress. Coal-fired power plants remain the primary power source in these regions due to their affordability and stability. However, these plants also contribute to severe air pollution and pose a significant threat to public health. This paper examines the impacts and underlying mechanisms of coal-fired power plants on local labor markets by pairing an instrumental variable approach with a quantitative spatial equilibrium model. Our empirical findings indicate competing forces: these plants enhance local firm productivity, driving population inflows, while simultaneously worsening local amenities via air pollution, leading to population outflows. Notably, at the granular county level, the productivity-driven inflow on average exceeds the amenity-driven outflow. By structuralizing these productivity and amenity channels within the quantitative framework, we conduct counterfactual simulations to quantify general equilibrium responses. These simulations uncover significant spatial heterogeneity and complex welfare redistributions resulting from localized capacity shocks. Ultimately, this study highlights the stark spatial trade-offs emerging economies face as they strive to balance the need for a stable electricity supply with environmental hazards.

Research Experience

Research Assistant for Prof. Ying Chen, XMU	12, 2021 – 06, 2023
• Conducted data cleaning, data visualization, and advanced regression analysis • Participated in weekly seminars, presenting and discussing frontier research papers	
Project Assistant for Prof. Jiong Zhu, XMU	10, 2021 – 02, 2022
• Analyzed unstructured datasets using NLP techniques for econometrics research	

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Mathematics for Economics (MSc), CUHK-SZ	2025 Summer
Teaching Assistant, Basic Macroeconomics (UG), CUHK-SZ	2026 Spring
Teaching Assistant, Introductory Econometrics (UG), CUHK-SZ	2025 Fall
Teaching Assistant, Urban Economics (UG), XMU	2021 Fall

Work Experience

Product Manager, Shanghai Pudong Development Bank (Wealth management)	07, 2023 – 01, 2024
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Awards & Honors

National Scholarship, XMU	2021
Teaching Assistant Award, XMU	2021
University Fellowships, SWUFE	2016–2019

Languages & Skills

Languages: English (fluent) and Mandarin (native)

Computer Languages: Python, R

Software: STATA, ArcGIS, L^AT_EX